

STIs, STDs, HIV and AIDS

Chapter objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. explain the meaning, causes, symptoms, mode of transmission and effects of STIs, STDs, and HIV and AIDS.
2. outline the preventive and control measures of STIs, STDs, and HIV and AIDS.
3. demonstrate necessary skills for avoiding risky situations, behaviour and practices.
4. outline the importance of curative health care for STIs, STDs and opportunistic diseases.
5. explain the importance of providing care and support to people living with HIV and AIDS and the effects of stigmatizing them.
6. outline necessary care and support services to be provided to people living with HIV and AIDS.

Key terms

- STI/STD
- HIV and AIDS
- opportunistic infection
- PLWHA
- stigmatization
- discrimination

Introduction

STI stands for **Sexually Transmitted Infection**. STD stands for **Sexually Transmitted Disease**. STIs and STDs are infections and diseases, respectively, that are spread through sexual intercourse or other forms of sexual contact. They are also sometimes referred to as venereal infections or venereal diseases, respectively.

HIV stands for **Human Immunodeficiency Virus**. This is a pathogen that causes the immune system to lose its efficiency. HIV causes AIDS. AIDS stands for **Acquired Immune Deficiency Syndrome**. People with AIDS get infections and diseases easily because their immune system is weakened.

STIs and STDs

STIs and STDs are common occurrences. However, many people are embarrassed when they get them and are therefore afraid to seek medical attention. This should not be the case. We should take care of our sexual health because it affects the overall health of the body.

Activity 8.1

Aim: To discuss about STIs and STDs.

Materials: Pamphlets, charts, magazines and slides on STIs and STDs, slide projector, notebook, and pen or pencil.

Procedure

1. In your discussion groups, discuss about STIs and STDs. Give examples of STIs and STDs and their effects.
2. Watch the slides and read the pamphlets, charts and magazines on STIs and STDs.
3. Write down the signs and symptoms of the various STIs and STDs.

Table 8.1 summarizes some common STIs and STDs and their causes, signs and symptoms, effects and how to prevent or control them.

Table 8.1 Causes, symptoms, effects, prevention and control of STIs and STDs

Infection/ Disease	Cause/Transmission	Signs/Symptoms	Effects	Prevention/Control
Gonorrhoea	Bacteria spread by: Sexual intercourse Sharing personal items such as towels, underwear and swimsuits An infected mother to her child at birth	Foul yellow discharge from the penis or vagina Pain when urinating Retention of urine in males Itching in the private parts Irregular menstruation	Infertility Swollen and painful joints	Abstain from sex Avoid sexual contact with infected people Do not share personal items such as towels, underwear and swimsuits Medical treatment
Syphilis	Bacteria spread by: Sexual intercourse A pregnant mother to the foetus in her womb Blood transfusion	Syphilis occurs in three stages: <i>First stage</i> (Occurs between 3–4 weeks after infection) Painless sore on sex organs Sore disappears after a week <i>Second stage</i> (Occurs between 8–14 weeks after infection) Fever Joint pains Rashes Raised bumps on the skin Swollen lymph nodes <i>Third stage</i> (Occurs 2 years after infection) In this stage the effects of syphilis are noticed	Damage to bones, teeth, skin, digestive system, eyes and nervous system Mental instability Blindness Stillborn babies Hearing problems Death	Abstain from sex Avoid sexual contact with infected people Use screened blood for transfusion Testing and treating pregnant women Medical treatment
Trichomoniasis	Protozoa spread by: Sexual intercourse Sharing personal items such as towels, underwear and swimsuits	Frothy smelly yellow discharge from the vagina Vaginal itching Pain when urinating (Men usually show no symptoms)	Low birth weight of babies Premature births	Abstain from sex Avoid sexual contact with infected people Do not share personal items such as towels, underwear or swimsuits Medical treatment for both partners even if one has no symptoms
Candidiasis	Fungus spread by: Sexual contact Sharing personal items such as towels, underwear and swimsuits	Thick white discharge from the vagina Vaginal itching Thick white patches in the mouth Inflammation of the glans of the penis Skin rashes	Infection of the bloodstream	Abstain from sex Avoid sexual contact with infected people Do not share personal items such as towels, underwear and swimsuits Medical treatment

Genital herpes	Viruses spread by: Sexual contact	Recurrent fever Ulcers or blisters around the penis or vagina Pain in or around the sex organs Headache	Recurrent painful ulcers Death of babies born to infected mothers	Abstain from sex Avoid sexual contact with infected people Medical treatment
Hepatitis B	Viruses spread by: Sexual contact Blood transfusion Contaminated blades and needles	Abdominal pain Jaundice (skin and eyes look yellowish) Dark urine Pale-coloured stool Nausea and vomiting Itching all over the body Feeling tired	Liver damage Liver cancer	Abstain from sex Vaccination Avoid sexual contact with infected people Do not share clinical needles and blades Use of screened blood for transfusion Medical treatment
Chlamydia	Bacteria spread by: Sexual intercourse Infected mother to her baby during birth	Bleeding from the vagina after sexual intercourse Bleeding between menstrual periods Lower abdominal pain Pain during urination Discharge from the penis or vagina Pain in the testicles (Most women show no symptoms)	Infertility	Abstain from sex Avoid sexual contact with infected people Medical treatment for both partners even if one does not show symptoms

HIV and AIDS

HIV is a deadly disease. It attacks a type of white blood cells (helper-T cells) which are essential for immunity. After an infection with HIV, a person can remain symptomless for many years during which the virus multiplies. The multiplication of HIV in the blood leads to massive destruction of helper-T cells. This weakens the immune system and the person develops full-blown AIDS. Due to low immunity the person gets diseases which would normally be fought off by the immune system. These diseases are called **opportunistic infections**. Examples of opportunistic infections are pneumonia, TB, diarrhoea and skin rashes. Death may result from these infections. Anti-retroviral drugs (ARVs) can slow the progress of AIDS but cannot cure it.

Transmission of HIV

HIV is found in body fluids of infected people, mostly blood, semen, vaginal secretions and breast milk. Sweat, saliva and tears have very low concentrations of the virus.

HIV can be spread by:

1. Sexual intercourse with an infected person.
2. Blood transfusion from an infected donor.

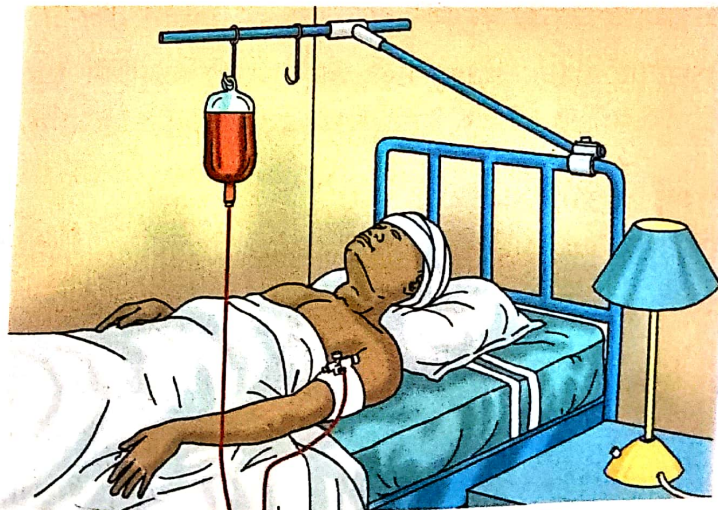


Fig. 8.1 Blood transfusion

3. Organ transplants from an infected donor.
4. An infected mother to her child during pregnancy, birth or breastfeeding.
5. Using unsterilized surgical or skin piercing instruments such as scalpels, needles and circumcision blades that have been used on a person infected with HIV.
6. Sharing toothbrushes, shaving blades or nail cutters with infected people.

Note: HIV is not spread by casual contact such as hugging, shaking hands or touching unless both people have bleeding wounds.



(a) Shaking hands



(b) Hugging

Fig. 8.2 Casual contacts

Symptoms of HIV and AIDS

There are four stages of HIV and AIDS:

Primary stage or window stage

This stage is accompanied by a flu-like illness. The HIV test is negative and a person looks healthy.

Asymptomatic stage

Asymptomatic stage has no symptoms but the HIV test is positive. The person still looks healthy.

Symptomatic stage

This stage is characterized by severe damage to the immune system.

Full-blown AIDS

In this stage, one gets various opportunistic infections and diseases. A person becomes very ill and weak.

The following symptoms may be noticed during the symptomatic and full-blown AIDS stage.

1. Loss of body weight by over five kilograms in two months.
2. Persistent fever that lasts for longer than a month.
3. Painless flat hard lumps growing on the skin or in the mouth.
4. Diarrhoea for longer than a month.
5. Coughing for more than a month.
6. Itchy rashes on the skin.
7. White layer in the mouth and throat (oral thrush).
8. Swollen glands, especially in the neck and armpits.
9. Shortness of breath, gradually getting worse.
10. Genital rashes.

Effects of HIV and AIDS

People with HIV and AIDS get opportunistic infections and diseases, for example:

1. Chest infections, such as pneumonia and tuberculosis.
2. Brain infections, leading to mental confusion, severe headache and fits (seizures).
3. Stomach or gut infections, leading to severe diarrhoea lasting for weeks.
4. Skin cancer, i.e. *Kaposi's sarcoma*.

Prevention and control

1. Avoid irresponsible sexual behaviour. Follow the ABC guide:
 - Abstain from sexual intercourse. This is the best method of prevention for the unmarried people
 - Be faithful to one sexual partner
 - Use a Condom during sexual intercourse.
2. Use sterilized instruments during surgery, circumcision and delivery.
3. Wear disposable gloves when touching other people's body fluids.

4. Only screened blood and organs should be used for transfusion and transplants, respectively.
5. Go for HIV test in order to know your status.
6. Do not share toothbrushes and shaving blades.
7. People with HIV and AIDS should be given anti-retroviral drugs (ARVs) which help to slow down the progression of the disease in the body.
8. Pregnant women should attend pre-natal clinics where they can be treated to prevent mother-to-child transmission.
9. HIV positive mothers should not breastfeed their newborn babies.

Activity 8.2

Aim: To discuss STIs, STDs, and HIV and AIDS.

Materials: Pamphlets, books, charts and fliers on STIs, STDs, and HIV and AIDS.

Procedure

1. Read the pamphlets, books, charts and fliers.
2. Discuss with your fellow students about risky behaviour or situations that can lead to being infected with STIs, STDs, and HIV and AIDS.
3. Role play types of risky behaviour that can lead to infection with STIs, STDs and HIV.
4. Discuss how you can avoid those situations or modes of behaviour.

Risky situations, behaviour and practices

There are activities and situations that put us at a greater risk of being infected with STIs, STDs and HIV. These include:

1. Transfusion using unscreened blood.
2. Sharing unsterilized needles and blades in health centres or when injecting drugs such as cocaine and heroine.

3. Drinking alcohol, smoking and using other drugs such as bhang, heroine and cocaine. Drugs impair our judgement ability and make us more likely to engage in unsafe sex.
4. Having immoral friends who pressure us into bad behaviour such as alcoholism and drug abuse.
5. Having many sexual partners.
6. Accepting favours and gifts such as money, clothes and mobile phones from members of the opposite sex. These people may expect sexual favours in return.
7. Having unprotected sex.
8. Failing to report sexual abuse or rape.
9. Staying in secluded places with members of the opposite sex.
10. Sharing personal items such as towels and swimsuits.
11. Going out alone or in the company of strangers, especially at night or visiting places such as bars, casinos and night clubs.
12. Sharing toothbrushes, needles and blades.

How to avoid risky practices, situations and behaviour

1. Abstain from sex before marriage.
2. Be faithful to one uninfected sexual partner after marriage or use a condom.
3. Only screened blood should be used for transfusion.
4. Do not share needles and blades. It is best to use disposable needles and blades. Dispose of them properly after use.
5. Avoid taking all forms of recreational drugs.
6. Keep good company. Avoid immoral friends.
7. Learn to resist peer pressure. Be firm and assertive when declining misleading advice.
8. Remember that often we cannot tell if someone is infected with HIV, STIs or STDs just by looking at them. Tests at a health facility are the only sure way of knowing whether or not a person is infected with HIV,

STIs or STDs. HIV and AIDS, STIs and STDs can infect people of any gender, age, religion or race.

Having sex with a virgin cannot cure HIV and AIDS. Touching, shaking hands with or hugging people cannot transmit HIV and AIDS.

9. Do not accept gifts or favours from members of the opposite sex.
10. Report all cases of sexual abuse, for example rape, to a trusted person and to the police. Go to a health facility as soon as possible.
11. Avoid staying in very secluded areas with members of the opposite sex.
12. Do not share personal items, e.g. toothbrushes, underwear, etc.
13. Go out in the company of trusted family members or friends.
14. Avoid risky places such as bars, night clubs and casinos.

Activity 8.3

Aim: To demonstrate necessary skills for avoiding risky behaviour.

Materials: Charts, magazines and pictures showing risky behaviour and how to avoid it.

Procedure

1. Together with your group members, look at the pictures and charts and read the magazines.
2. Role play how to use various life skills to avoid risky behaviour.
3. Discuss how you can acquire the skills needed to avoid risky behaviour.

Importance of health care for STIs, STDs and opportunistic diseases

People who suspect that they have STIs, STDs or HIV and AIDS should seek medical care as soon as possible for the following reasons:

1. Early testing and treatment will help to treat or slow down the development of the infection or disease in its early stages.

2. Proper treatment can save life and prevent long-term effects such as infertility.
3. Health care professionals can give appropriate counselling on how to manage the infections and diseases and how to avoid re-infection.
4. Testing gives peace of mind. It confirms whether one is infected or not, instead of worrying and guessing what the problem could be.
5. Proper health care reduces the chances of infecting other people.
6. We should not be embarrassed to seek medical advice on STIs, STDs, and HIV and AIDS.

Care and support for People Living With HIV and AIDS (PLWHA)

People with HIV and AIDS can live healthy lives for a long time if they get proper care and support. We can care for them and support them in the following ways:

1. Giving them well-balanced meals in adequate quantities.
2. Allowing them to rest when they feel unwell.
3. Taking them to a health centre as soon as they start developing signs of illness.

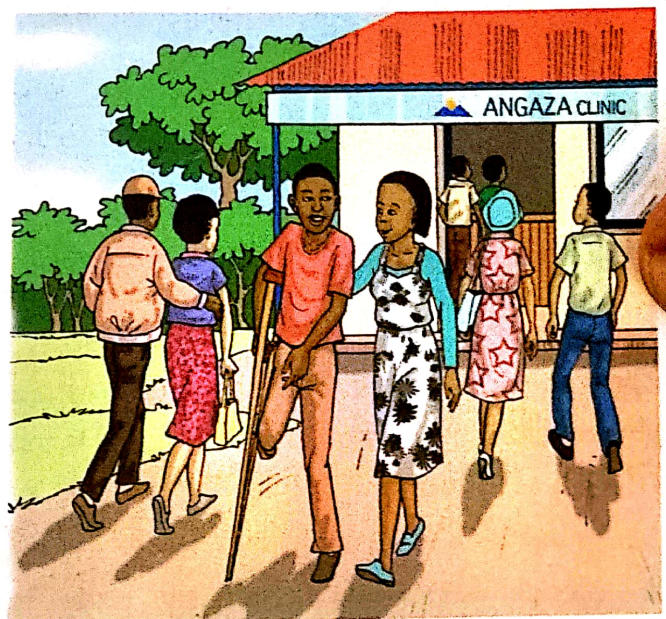


Fig. 8.3 Angaza centres provide HIV and AIDS information and medical care

4. Providing them with ARVs which help to slow down the advancement of the condition.
5. Allowing them to work and exercise if they can.
6. Behaving in a loving way towards them.
7. Listening to them and helping them when they have problems.
8. Counselling them to stop behaviour that could worsen their condition, for example taking drugs or having many sexual partners.
9. Not discriminating against them or stigmatizing them by doing the following:
 - (i) Branding them names such as 'walking corpse'
 - (ii) Denying them work opportunities
 - (iii) Denying them education or health services
 - (iv) Chasing them away from home
 - (v) Refusing to share utensils or rooms with them
 - (vi) Not involving them in decision-making
 - (vii) Hiding them from the public.
10. Keeping their bodies, clothing and bedding clean.

Remember to keep any wounds covered and to always wear disposable gloves when handling faeces, urine, blood or vomit from infected people.

Care and support gives PLWHA hope, good health, peace of mind, long life, strength to work and comfort.

Discrimination leads to depression, loneliness, loss of hope, poor health, hastened death and poor performance at work and school.

Activity 8.4

Aim: To discuss how to care for PLWHA.

1. In your discussion groups, discuss and role play how you can give care and support to PLWHA.
2. Discuss the importance of giving care and support to PLWHA.

3. Role play how to care for PLWHA in the society.
4. Discuss incidences of stigma and discrimination against PLWHA in your community.
5. Discuss the effects of stigma and discrimination on PLWHA.

Chapter summary

1. STI stands for '*Sexually Transmitted Infection*'.
2. STD stands for '*Sexually Transmitted Disease*'.
3. HIV stands for '*Human Immunodeficiency Virus*'.
4. AIDS stands for '*Acquired Immune Deficiency Syndrome*'.
5. HIV and AIDS occurs in four stages:
 - (i) Primary or window stage
 - (ii) Asymptomatic stage
 - (iii) Symptomatic stage
 - (iv) Full-blown AIDS.
6. PLWHA stands for '*People Living With HIV and AIDS*'.
7. Examples of STIs and STDs are:
 - (i) Gonorrhoea
 - (ii) Syphilis
 - (iii) Trichomoniasis
 - (iv) Candidiasis
 - (v) Genital herpes
 - (vi) Hepatitis B
 - (vii) Chlamydia.
8. HIV weakens the body's immunity and causes a person to get opportunistic infections.
9. People may have STIs, STDs or HIV and AIDS and yet show no symptoms. Only clinical tests can confirm whether or not a person is infected.
10. People with HIV and AIDS can live long healthy lives if they get proper care and support.
11. We should avoid risky situations, behaviour and practices to avoid being infected with STIs, STDs, and HIV and AIDS.

Review exercise

1. Define the following terms.
 - (i) STI (ii) STD (iii) HIV
 - (iv) Opportunistic infection (v) ARV
2. Write **True** for statements that are true and **False** for statements that are not true.
 - (i) There is no health care available for people with STDs.
 - (ii) Syphilis can lead to brain damage.
 - (iii) Hepatitis B is caused by bacteria.
 - (iv) Towels cannot spread STIs.
 - (v) STDs can be treated using painkillers only.
3. Using examples,
 - (i) mention five ways of preventing STIs.
 - (ii) briefly explain five ways through which you can be infected with HIV.
 - (iii) outline five habits that can lead to being infected with STIs and STDs.
 - (iv) mention five ways in which people with HIV and AIDS are stigmatized in the society.
 - (v) give two precautions that you should take when caring for PLWHA.
4. Choose the correct answer from the choices given.
 - (i) Which of the following is NOT transmitted by sexual contact?
 - A. HIV and AIDS
 - B. Malaria
 - C. Hepatitis B
 - D. Gonorrhoea
 - (ii) _____ is caused by a virus.
 - A. Trichomoniasis
 - B. Syphilis
 - C. Genital herpes
 - D. Candidiasis
 - (iii) Caring for PLWHA is important because _____.
 - A. it can cure AIDS
 - B. it gives the patient hope
 - C. the patient gets many visitors
 - D. it makes the patient depressed
 - (iv) Hepatitis B can be prevented by _____.
 - A. vaccination
 - B. using mosquito nets
 - C. eating a balanced diet
 - D. not shaking hands with infected people
 - (v) Genital herpes can cause all the following except _____.
 - A. painful ulcers
 - B. blindness
 - C. death of babies born to infected mothers
 - D. recurrent fever
 - (vi) The second stage of HIV and AIDS _____.
 - A. has flu-like symptoms
 - B. is full-blown AIDS
 - C. has no symptoms
 - D. leads to syphilis
 - (vii) The following are symptoms of the second stage of syphilis except _____.
 - A. painless sore on sex organ
 - B. swollen lymph nodes
 - C. joint pains
 - D. fever
5. List three STIs and STDs caused by:
 - (i) Viruses (ii) Bacteria
6. Write short notes on the following:
 - (i) Stages of HIV and AIDS
 - (ii) Prevention and control of HIV and AIDS.
7. How can the following risky behaviour or practices keep a person in danger of contracting HIV?
 - (i) Drinking alcohol
 - (ii) Sharing razor blades
 - (iii) Sexual promiscuity
 - (iv) Drug abuse